

STAGE ONE • SELF-AWARENESS & CAREER CLARITY

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage One • Self-Awareness & Career Clarity

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice — it's a safety net, not a requirement to sound scripted.

It's organized into four parts: session openings (the first two minutes of each session, which set the tone for everything after), transitions (the handful of sentences that connect one FIRST to the next so the session doesn't feel like a disconnected checklist), discussion prompting (what to actually say in five common live moments), and tricky moments (specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck, defensive, or uncomfortable, with suggested language to navigate it).

Experienced facilitators should feel free to use this as a reference rather than a script. First-time facilitators are encouraged to genuinely read the opening and transition lines closely, at least for your first cohort — they do real work.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

“Welcome, everyone. Over the next few weeks, we're going to work through eighteen ‘FIRSTS’ — specific, concrete steps most people figure out by accident, years into their career, if they figure them out at all. We're doing them on purpose, and early.”

“Today's session is called Foundations of Self. Before we look outward at industries and roles, we're going to look inward: what do you actually value, where do you want to go, and what are you genuinely good at? Everything we do in later sessions builds on what we do today — so it's worth taking seriously even though it might feel less ‘practical’ than resume-building.”

“A quick ground rule: some of what we do today is personal. You're never required to share more than you're comfortable with. I'll always tell you clearly when something is opt-in versus when I'm asking everyone to contribute.”

Opening Session 2

“Last time, we worked on values, vision, purpose, brand, strengths, and weaknesses — all internal. Today we turn outward: industries, roles, pay, and a clear-eyed SWOT that pulls the last two sessions together.”

“This session needs real research, so have your laptop or phone ready. If you don't have a specific target role yet, that's completely fine — pick your best current guess. The point isn't to be right yet, it's to practice the research process.”

Opening Session 3

“Today is about how you work, not just what you want to do. We're going to look at your skill growth plan, your personality, your work style, how you make decisions, how you learn, and how you actually get focused — six FIRSTS that are all genuinely personal. There's no right answer to any of them, only an honest one.”

“Two of today's FIRSTS — Work Style and Learning Style — run over the next several days, not just today. I'll walk you through how to set those up before we close.”

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises turns a checklist into a coherent narrative. These aren't required word-for-word, but the connective logic behind each one is worth preserving.

FIRST 01 → 02

"You've just named three things you won't compromise on. Career Vision is where we start imagining what you're building toward, using those values as the foundation — not separate from them."

FIRST 03 → 04

"Purpose is the why. Now we need language for the what — how you'd actually describe yourself to someone who's never met you. That's your brand narrative."

FIRST 05 → 06

"We just spent twenty minutes on what you're good at. This next one is going to feel different — we're going to look honestly at what's not yet strong. That's not a punishment, it's the other half of an accurate picture."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Everything we did today was internal — values, vision, strengths. Next session, we take all of that and point it outward: what industries, roles, and paths actually fit what we just discovered about you."

FIRST 09 → 10

"Now that you can see how a role family unfolds over time, let's zoom into one specific role and get genuinely concrete about what it actually requires."

FIRST 11 → 12

"You now know roughly what this role pays. Let's put everything from today and last session together into one honest picture — that's the SWOT."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You now know what you value, what you're good at, and what the market looks like. The last piece is understanding how you actually work — your personality, your habits, your focus. That's today."

FIRST 16 → 17

"We just looked at how you decide. Now let's look at how you learn — a closely related but genuinely distinct question."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up in almost every cohort, with suggested language for each.

Room stays silent after a question

“That's okay — take thirty more seconds to actually think about it, no need to have a polished answer. I'll come back to this in a minute.” (Wait it out. Don't rush to fill the silence yourself — the silence is doing real work.)

One person is dominating the conversation

“That's a great point — I want to make sure we hear a couple of other perspectives on this too. [Name], what's your take?”

Someone gives a surface-level answer and you want to go deeper

“Say more about that — what specifically made that true for you?” or “Can you give me a real example of that?”

A participant seems visibly uncomfortable during Weakness Awareness (06)

“You don't have to share the weakness itself if you'd rather not — just naming your thirty-day action, if you're comfortable, is genuinely enough.”

Someone challenges the value of an exercise (“this feels like a waste of time”)

“That's fair, and I'd rather you tell me that than silently disengage. Can I ask what specifically feels off? Sometimes that tells us the exercise needs adjusting, and sometimes it tells us something real about resistance worth naming.”

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get stuck, defensive, or uncomfortable — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST 01

Core Values Audit

FACILITATOR NOTE

Participants often initially list values that are actually inherited (from family, culture) rather than genuinely their own. If someone's list feels generic or expected, gently ask: "Is that a value you'd choose even if no one was watching or judging you?"

FIRST 06

Weakness Awareness

FACILITATOR NOTE

This is the most emotionally loaded FIRST in the stage. Some participants will want to minimize ("I don't really have weaknesses") and others will spiral into self-criticism. Both are worth naming gently: "The goal here isn't judgment in either direction — it's just an honest, useful list."

FIRST 11

Salary Benchmarking

FACILITATOR NOTE

Numbers can trigger real anxiety, especially for participants from backgrounds where salary wasn't openly discussed. Normalize it explicitly: "Most people have never seen real numbers for their target role. That's exactly the gap we're closing today — there's no wrong starting point."

FIRST 14

Personality Assessment

FACILITATOR NOTE

Watch for participants treating their type as a fixed identity ("I'm an INTJ so I just can't do networking"). Redirect firmly but kindly: "This is a tendency, not a ceiling. What would it look like to work with that tendency instead of hiding behind it?"